him discussing them. It was during his state visit to China, while he was touring Beijing University. Almost spontaneously, several hundred (perhaps even thousands) of students gathered in a spacious hall to welcome him. He took the stage and delivered a long lecture in eloquent English, without any notes or prior preparation, about the history of the Jewish people and its state. The main message of his lecture to the Chinese students was that while the great Chinese nation had been around for six thousand years, the tiny Jewish nation had also survived for more than five thousand years, and would continue to do so for all eternity.

The man radiated wisdom—not the kind acquired at school or university but the kind attained in the school of life. It was a wisdom that reflected personal experience, the result of carrying the burden and working for decades toward one great purpose—the existence and security of the Jewish people in its land.

The prime minister's superb analytical abilities were well known. His unique talent lay in the fact that he could grasp complex situations and issues, break them down into simple elements, and in straightforward Hebrew, in four- or five-word sentences, draw out the essence and make it clear and understandable for everyone around him. Often, after hearing him analyze an issue, I would ask myself how it was that I had not seen it that way before and would marvel at how simple and understandable it seemed after the prime minister's analysis.

He always put the country first. When I look back on all of my years of work with him, I cannot point to a single case in which a decision of his was tainted by personal or party considerations. I do not remember him ever taking advantage of the tremendous power that was concentrated in his hands as prime minister and defense minister for a cause that was not in the best interest of the state. He forbade us, the members of the intelligence community, to place considerations of discretion and security above national considerations, even in extreme cases in which the result would be sacrificing intelligence or security activities.

Yitzhak Rabin was a leader. In the security-intelligence establishment there is a hierarchy in which each level examines itself in comparison to the echelon above it and also seeks from it reinforcement and inspiration. This interrelationship is both logical and wise when dealing with activities in which the risk calculation between the benefits of success and the damage of failure is taken from a world of concepts with which the public is